Harbour Light Cooperative

Annual report 2026 · A year of community energy

Prepared by the board for members · 14 March 2027

Contents

Summary **2**

Background **2**

How decisions are made 2

What we built **2**

Results **3**

The neighbourhood **4**

Finances **4**

Next year **5**

Plans 5

How you can help 5

Summary

Harbour Light finished its fourth year with **1,284 members**, two new solar roofs and the first battery store owned by a neighbourhood in the county. Members saved an average of 23 % on their electricity bills, and the cooperative ended the year with a small surplus that goes back into the repair fund.

This report explains what we built, what it cost, what worked and what didn't. Figures are for the calendar year unless stated otherwise; the full accounts are available to every member on request.

Background

The cooperative was founded in 2022 by thirty households who wanted cheaper, cleaner power and a say in how it is produced. Membership costs one share, and every member has one vote, whatever the size of their roof.[1]

Our first project, the school roof, has produced electricity every day since it was switched on. The second and third projects followed in 2025. This year was about storage: keeping the sun's energy for the evening, when the street needs it most.

How decisions are made

- The general meeting elects the board and approves the budget
- The board meets monthly; minutes are published within a week
- Any ten members can put a proposal on the agenda

What we built

Two roofs were added this year: the sports hall on Quay Street and the library annexe. Together they add 148 kilowatts of panels. The battery store next to the community centre holds 420 kilowatt-hours, enough to cover the street lights and the centre through most winter evenings.

[1] One share costs €50 and can be paid back when a member leaves; it does not earn interest.

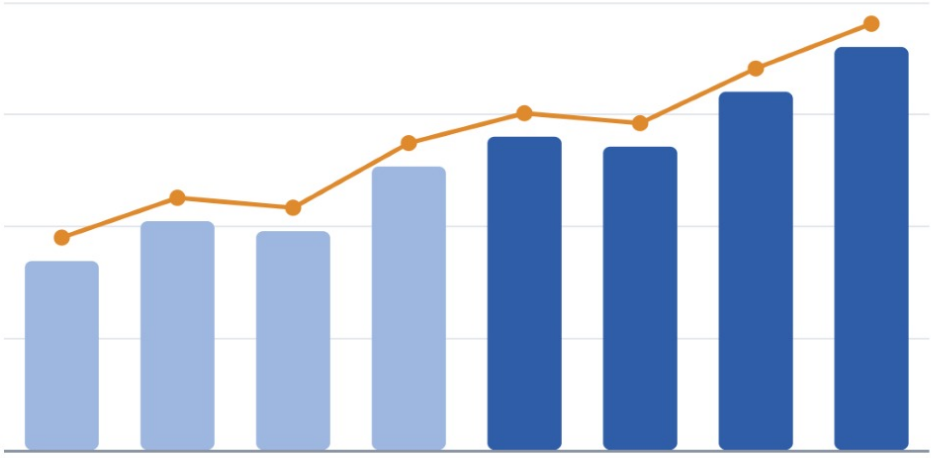


Figure 1. Electricity produced per quarter, in megawatt-hours. The darker bars are 2026.

Production grew in every quarter but one. The dip in the third quarter came from a week of maintenance on the school roof, planned for the summer holidays.

Results

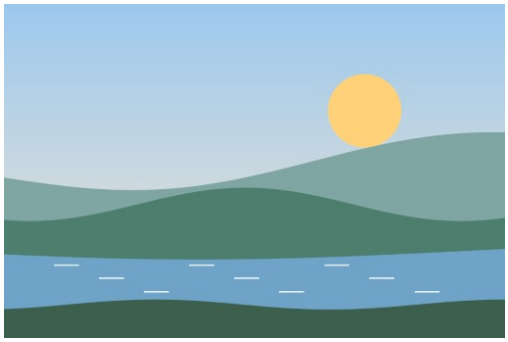
The table below compares the year with the one before. The biggest change is in how much of our electricity is used right here, thanks to the battery (Table 1).

Measure	2025	2026	Change
Members	1,032	1,284	+24 %
Electricity produced	212 MWh	263 MWh	+24 %
Used locally	61 %	78 %	+17 points
Average bill saving	18 %	23 %	+5 points
Volunteer hours	2,140	2,960	+38 %
Surplus	€4,200	€11,900	+183 %

Table 1. The year in numbers.

Using our own electricity locally matters more than producing more of it: every kilowatt-hour used on the street is worth about three times what the grid pays us for it.[2]

The neighbourhood



The battery changed the way the street works. On summer evenings the community centre runs on stored sunshine until well after dark, and the café next door has started opening late on Fridays. Several members told us they now plan laundry and cooking for the sunny part of the day, because the app shows when the panels are producing more than the street needs.

We also ran six open days, a repair café and a course for teenagers who want to become electricians. The course was full within a week; we will run it twice next year.

Not everything worked. The car-sharing trial ended early because too few members needed a car at the same time of day, and the first version of the app confused more people than it helped. Both lessons are reflected in next year's plan.

> *We used to talk about energy as something that arrives through a cable. Now we talk about it like the weather: something we share, watch and plan around.*

Finances

Income came from three sources, in this order of size:

1. Electricity sold to members at the cooperative rate
2. Electricity exported to the grid at the contract tariff
3. A one-off grant for the battery store

Costs were close to the budget. Insurance rose more than expected and the battery's installation took two weeks longer than planned, which we paid for from the

[2] Based on the 2026 average retail price and the export tariff in our contract with the grid operator.

contingency line. The surplus of €11,900 goes to the repair fund, as the general meeting decided.[3]

Next year

Plans

- A fifth roof: the bus depot, if the city agrees to a twenty-year lease
- A simpler app, designed with the members who found the first one hard
- Two more teenager courses and a mentoring programme

How you can help

Come to the general meeting on 18 April, bring a neighbour, and tell us what you think. The agenda and the full accounts are on the members' page.

[3] The repair fund now holds €38,400, enough to replace the inverters on all four roofs once.